Kamar M. Boloto

Atty. Kamar M. Boloto, CPA was a Filipino lawyer, certified public accountant, and institutional leader from Malabang, Lanao del Sur whose historic academic achievements made him one of the most celebrated figures in Bangsamoro history.

He is best remembered for a feat no Muslim Filipino had accomplished before him: topping the Certified Public Accountant (CPA) Board Examinations outright, and then going on to place 2nd in the 1970 Philippine Bar Examinations with a remarkable average of 86.75%.

Together, these two milestones earned him what his community calls the "Double Crown of Excellence," a legacy that continues to inspire generations of Maranao and Muslim Filipino professionals long after his time.

Beyond the examination halls, Boloto gave the rest of his career to building institutions. He served as Director of the Finance Division at Mindanao State University (MSU-Marawi), and he was among the key proponents who pushed for the establishment of MSU-Malabang, bringing higher education to his own hometown on the Lanao coast.

His story is not just about individual brilliance. It's about what that brilliance meant to a community still fighting for its place in the Philippine professional mainstream.

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Atty. Kamar M. Boloto, CPA



Born	Malabang, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Ethnicity	Maranao
Alma mater	University of the East (College of Law)
Known for	2nd Place, 1970 Philippine Bar Examinations; First Muslim to top the CPA Board Examinations
Bar Exam Result	2nd Place (1970), 86.75%
CPA Exam Result	1st Place (Rank 1); First Muslim topnotcher
Profession	Lawyer, Certified Public Accountant
Employer	Mindanao State University (MSU-Marawi)
Notable work	Director of Finance Division, MSU; Co-proponent of MSU-Malabang

Early Life and Heritage

Atty. Boloto was born and raised in Malabang, Lanao del Sur, a coastal municipality with deep historical roots as a former seat of power linked to both the Sultanate of Maguindanao and the princely states of Lanao.<ref name="malabang_history">Malabang is recognized as one of the oldest municipalities in Mindanao, historically associated with the spread of Islam in the Lake Lanao region.</ref>

He was a proud member of the Maranao tribe, whose name means "People of the Lake," referring to their ancestral homeland surrounding Lake Lanao.<ref name="maranao_identity">The Maranao are one of the major Muslim ethnolinguistic groups in Mindanao, known for their elaborate artistic traditions, oral literature, and the concept of *Maratabat* (honor and self-worth).</ref>

Growing up in Malabang meant growing up at the intersection of Islamic tradition and the practical demands of mid-20th century Philippine society. The values instilled in him early, particularly *Maratabat* (a deep sense of honor and personal worth) and *Kanggiginawai* (mutual respect and dignity in one's conduct), were not just cultural ornaments. They became the internal compass that drove his extraordinary discipline in academia and public service.

His hometown was no stranger to leadership. Malabang had produced local officials, religious scholars, and community figures, but no one from its ranks had yet broken into the national topnotcher lists of the country's most prestigious professional examinations. Boloto would change that.

Education

Law: University of the East College of Law

Atty. Boloto pursued his legal education at the University of the East (UE) College of Law in Manila, an institution that had built a reputation as a "cradle of topnotchers" in Philippine bar history.<ref name="ue_college_of_law">The University of the East College of Law has produced numerous bar topnotchers and prominent legal practitioners throughout the 20th century.</ref>

In 1970, he sat for the Philippine Bar Examinations, the country's most demanding professional licensure test for aspiring lawyers. He placed **2nd nationwide**, with an average of **86.75%**, a score that placed him firmly among the country's brightest legal minds of his generation.<ref name="1970_bar_results">Philippine Bar Examination results for 1970, as administered by the Supreme Court of the Philippines.</ref>

His achievement was particularly significant in context. He was the first Filipino Muslim to break into the Top 10 of the Bar Examinations since the post-war period, following the pioneering example of Macapanton Abbas Sr., who had placed 2nd in the Bar in the 1940s.<ref name="macapanton_reference">Macapanton Abbas Sr. is recognized as one of the earliest Muslim Filipino topnotchers in the Philippine Bar Examinations.</ref>

Accountancy: The First Muslim CPA Topnotcher

Before his legal triumph, Boloto had already made history in the field of accountancy.

He became the **first Muslim Filipino to top the CPA Board Examinations** outright, taking the Rank 1 position and earning the title of Certified Public Accountant.<ref name="cpa_topnotcher">Boloto's achievement in the CPA Board Examinations marked a historic first for Muslim Filipino representation among national board topnotchers in the Philippines.</ref>

This dual mastery of Law and Accountancy was rare then as it is now. It gave him a professional profile that was uniquely suited for institutional leadership, combining legal acumen with fiscal rigor in a single person.

Career

Finance Division Director, Mindanao State University

After his licensure examinations, Atty. Boloto dedicated a significant portion of his professional life to Mindanao State University (MSU), the flagship state university serving the Muslim and indigenous communities of Mindanao.

He served as the **Director of the Finance Division** at MSU-Marawi, overseeing the university's budgetary and fiscal operations during one of its most critical expansion phases in the 1970s.<ref name="msu_code_1976">MSU Code of 1976, BOR Resolution No. 1280, Mindanao State University Board of Regents. His role in the Finance Division is documented within the university's official governance records of the period.</ref>

His contributions during this period are formally acknowledged in the **MSU Code of 1976** (BOR Resolution No. 1280), which structured the university's fiscal governance policies at a time when MSU was rapidly growing to serve a larger student population across Mindanao.

Managing the finances of a regional state university in the 1970s was no small feat. The period coincided with the Marcos martial law era and the escalating conflict in Mindanao, both of which created fiscal pressures that demanded careful, principled administration. Boloto navigated these challenges with the same discipline that had defined his academic career.

Establishing MSU-Malabang

Perhaps the most enduring mark Atty. Boloto left on his community was his role in bringing the Mindanao State University system to his own hometown.

Driven by a genuine desire to democratize access to higher education in the Lanao coastal area, he became one of the primary proponents of establishing an MSU branch in Malabang, Lanao del Sur.

Working closely with **MSU President Ali Dimaporo**, Boloto formally submitted the municipal resolution that called for the creation of MSU-Malabang.<ref name="bor_1589">Board of Regents Resolution No. 1589, Series of 1978, Mindanao State University. Signed on August 1, 1978. This resolution formally authorized the establishment of MSU-Malabang.</ref>

BOR Resolution No. 1589 was signed on **August 1, 1978**, officially authorizing the establishment of MSU-Malabang. That date marks a milestone not just for Malabang but for the entire Lanao coastal corridor, where young people now had access to affordable tertiary education without having to travel to Marawi or Manila.

MSU-Malabang continues to operate today, and its founding story carries Boloto's name as one of the men who made it happen.

Cultural Significance

Atty. Boloto's legacy cannot be fully understood outside of its social and historical context.

In 1970, when he placed 2nd in the Bar, Muslim-Christian tensions in Mindanao were already escalating toward what would become the armed conflict of the early 1970s and the imposition of martial law. Against this backdrop, a young Maranao man from a small coastal town standing near the top of the country's most prestigious professional examination was more than a personal achievement. It was a statement.

> He showed that the Bangsamoro people belong not just on the battlefield of political struggle, but in the highest halls of Philippine intellectual and professional life.

His success challenged stereotypes about Muslim Filipinos that had long been used to marginalize the community. He did it not through protest or politics, but through extraordinary academic performance, a form of assertion that was peaceful, undeniable, and impossible to dismiss.

Decades later, the **Bangsamoro Parliament** and the **National Commission on Muslim Filipinos** (NCMF) continue to cite Atty. Boloto as a foundational inspiration for current Muslim bar and board topnotchers.<ref name="ncmf_reference">National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF), documentation on Bangsamoro professional achievers cited in institutional advocacy materials.</ref>

His name is invoked not as nostalgia, but as a living benchmark: what is possible when a Bangsamoro Filipino is given the opportunity, and takes it.

Legacy and Recognition

The "Double Crown of Excellence" is the phrase most associated with Atty. Boloto's legacy: the rare combination of topping the CPA Board and placing 2nd in the Philippine Bar, two of the most competitive professional examinations in the country.

He established a high-water mark for Maranao and Muslim Filipino academic achievement at the national level, one that stood as an aspirational reference point for the community for generations.

His generational influence is reflected in the Boloto family name's continuing presence in academia. His son, **Kamar V. Boloto Jr.**, followed his path as an educator and professional at MSU, carrying forward a family tradition of service to the same institution his father helped shape.<ref name="boloto_family">Details of Kamar V. Boloto Jr.'s professional association with Mindanao State University are noted in community records relating to the Boloto family's contributions to the MSU system.</ref>

The establishment of MSU-Malabang, formalized through BOR Resolution No. 1589 in 1978, stands as his most concrete and lasting institutional contribution: a campus that continues to educate the sons and daughters of the Lanao coast, long after his own career had passed.

See Also

- Maranao people
- Mindanao State University
- MSU-Malabang
- Malabang, Lanao del Sur
- Lake Lanao
- Philippine Bar Examinations
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Macapanton Abbas Sr.
- Maratabat

Further Reading

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- McKenna, Thomas M. *Muslim Rulers and Rebels: Everyday Politics and Armed Separatism in the Southern Philippines.* University of California Press, 1998.

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